of ritual action, subsequent to initiation (*diksha*) into the cult thanks to God's grace (*anugraha*). Following the ritual path just for its own sake will not generate ***karma***. More crucially, it helps to remove an innate defect (***mala***) that has radically restricted the souls' potentially infinite innate powers of knowledge and action. ***Mala*** is ultimately responsible for subjection to ***karma*** and rebirth. Salvation, granted by *Shiva* when he judges the soul ready for it, is understood as becoming all powerful and all knowing, like the godhead.

Shiva is conceived as a deity with an interest in the world that is compassionately disposed towards ***mala***-stricken human beings. He is said to possess an unlimited power (***shakti*** – which may be represented as his female partner) comprising knowledge and action. He is all pervasive, not a being among beings. He is differentiated from the liberated souls by the fact that he is never subject to finite conditions.

Mala is a material substance (***dravya***) and needs an action to remove it. Knowledge of its presence is not enough. Whereas the *Tantric* votaries of the ferocious deities *Bhairava* and *Kali* believe that sectarian initiation annuls one's former caste, *Shaiva Siddhantin* initiation leaves ***caste***, understood as an intrinsic physical property, intact. The initiate is thus able to fulfil his orthodox Brahminical social and ritual duties. His life of ritual duty, combining both orthodox and *Tantric* commitments, is consistent with mainstream orthodox Brahminical duty and caste purity (*varna-ashrama-dharma*).

The eternally real material cause of the physical universe is called ***maya***. *Shiva* operates on this to create environments so that souls, embodied with limited powers of knowledge and action, may be freed from their ***karma*** by experiencing its fruits. *Shaiva Siddhantins* believe that creation and the organisation of spheres of experience